PARIS, FRANCE

Musée national Picasso-Paris: Masterpieces

Twenty works that keep recognition alive while altering anatomy, scale and materials.



A saddle and a handlebar can become a bull without ceasing to be bicycle parts. That double recognition offers a useful entry into this selection. Picasso's painted figures also keep enough familiar signs to remain readable while their proportions, contours and viewpoints change.

There is no single direction from realistic youth to abstract maturity here. The observed weight of a seated child, the mass of a bather and an acrobat's implausible curve answer different pictorial problems. Works by Seurat and Courbet provide comparisons rather than steps in Picasso's development. Follow a recurring subject through the selection and ask what has been retained, what has been altered, and what the alteration allows the image to do.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/musee-picasso-paris

The selection · 20

1. Bathers on the Beach
   Pablo Picasso · 1928
2. Jacqueline with Flowers
   Pablo Picasso · 1954
3. Seated Woman
   Georges Seurat · 1881
4. The Barefoot Girl
   Pablo Picasso · 1895
5. Bull's Head
   Pablo Picasso · 1942
6. Head of a Goat
   Gustave Courbet · 1875
7. Bust of a Woman in a Striped Hat
   Pablo Picasso · 1939
8. Two Nude Women on the Beach
   Pablo Picasso · 1937
9. Sleeping Woman with Shutters
   Pablo Picasso · 1936
10. Child Playing with a Truck
    Pablo Picasso · 1953
11. Women in an Interior
    Pablo Picasso · 1936
12. Figure and Profile
    Pablo Picasso · 1928
13. Large Bather with a Book
    Pablo Picasso · 1937
14. Large Still Life on a Pedestal Table
    Pablo Picasso · 1931
15. The Acrobat
    Pablo Picasso · 1930
16. Child with Doves
    Pablo Picasso · 1943
17. Straw Hat with Blue Foliage
    Pablo Picasso · 1936
18. Paul as Harlequin
    Pablo Picasso · 1924
19. Massacre in Korea
    Pablo Picasso · 1951
20. Maya with a Doll
    Pablo Picasso · 1938

01 / 20

Bathers on the Beach

Pablo Picasso

1928 · Oil on canvas · Musée national Picasso-Paris



Pablo Picasso. Bathers on the beach. WikiArt source label: Pablo Picasso Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/pablo-picasso/bathers-on-the-beach-1928 · Pablo Picasso Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

Blue water establishes the setting before the angular orange forms resolve into bathers. Picasso has removed much of the anatomy that would ordinarily explain a pose. Position and relative scale take over that work. The figures remain bodies because a few signs hold together, not because every limb has a convincing counterpart in a person standing on a beach.

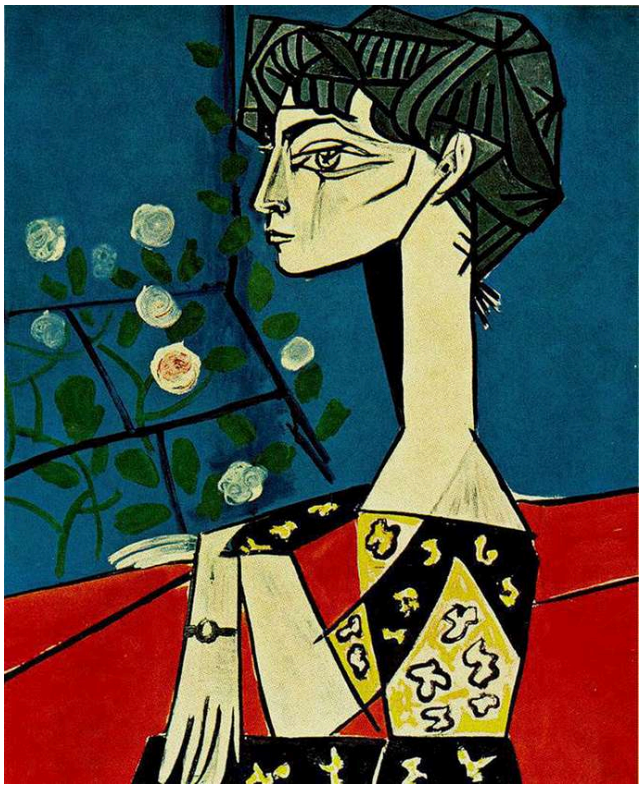
Object source · Open artwork

02 / 20

Jacqueline with Flowers

Pablo Picasso

1954 · Oil on canvas · Musée national Picasso-Paris



Pablo Picasso. Jacqueline with flowers. WikiArt source label: Pablo Picasso Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/pablo-picasso/jacqueline-with-flowers-1954 · Pablo Picasso Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

Jacqueline's profile forms a firm edge against the blue ground. Flowering stems and patterned clothing introduce smaller, more irregular movements around that outline. The long neck keeps the head distinct from the busier area below. Rather than blending sitter and decoration into a single texture, the portrait allows her still contour to resist the surrounding pattern.

Object source · Open artwork

03 / 20

Seated Woman

Georges Seurat

1881 · Crayon on paper · Musée national Picasso-Paris



Seated Woman. WikiArt; Georges Seurat. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

Seurat's figure becomes solid through the accumulation of dark marks. Where the marks thin out, the body approaches the lightness of the paper instead of meeting a continuous boundary. This is a useful counterpoint to Picasso's emphatic contours elsewhere in the guide: a seated body can be established by changing density without first enclosing it in a line.

Object source · Open artwork

04 / 20

The Barefoot Girl

Pablo Picasso

1895 · Oil on canvas · Musée national Picasso-Paris



Pablo Picasso. The barefoot girl. WikiArt source label: Public domain US. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/pablo-picasso/the-barefoot-girl-1895 · Public domain US (WikiArt source label)

Folded hands and exposed feet anchor the upright girl in her seat. Her red dress separates her from the dark foliage, but the pose remains unshowy. This early work establishes how much Picasso could obtain from a sustained, relatively conventional portrait. Later distortions need not be read as an escape from an inability to describe weight or bodily proportion.

Object source · Open artwork

05 / 20

Bull's Head

Pablo Picasso

1942 · Assemblage , objet trouve · Musée national Picasso-Paris



Pablo Picasso. Bull's Head. WikiArt source label: Pablo Picasso Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/pablo-picasso/bulls-head-1942 · Pablo Picasso Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

The museum identifies the materials as an actual leather saddle and metal handlebar. Their earlier use remains easy to recognise: the narrow saddle becomes a muzzle, the curving handlebar becomes horns. Nothing needs to be disguised with realistic fur or modelled eyes. The sculpture holds together two identifications, allowing a bicycle and a bull to occupy the same small arrangement.

Object source · Open artwork

06 / 20

Head of a Goat

Gustave Courbet

1875 · Musée national Picasso-Paris



Gustave Courbet. Head of a goat. Image credit: Gustave Courbet. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Courbet approaches an animal head by describing its particular anatomy. Light catches the eye and muzzle beneath the sweep of the horns; mountain and sky give the head a setting. Beside Picasso's assembled bull, the difference is instructive. One image specifies flesh and texture, while the other recruits existing objects. Both depend on the recognisability of a few relations.

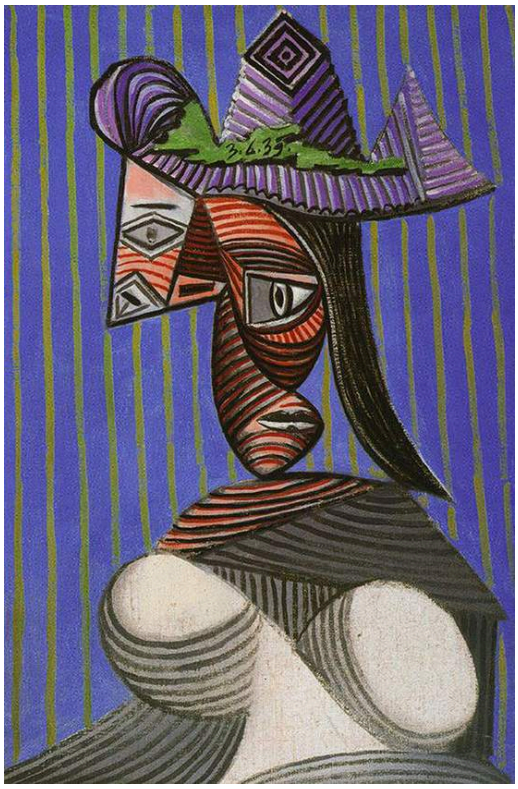
Object source · Open artwork

07 / 20

Bust of a Woman in a Striped Hat

Pablo Picasso

1939 · Musée national Picasso-Paris



Pablo Picasso. Bust of woman. WikiArt source label: Pablo Picasso Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/pablo-picasso/bust-of-woman-1939 · Pablo Picasso Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

Stripes do not stop at the border between costume and person. They help divide the woman's face and clothing, while the background continues the vertical rhythm. The features remain identifiable but no longer occupy a smoothly continuous surface. Picasso makes pattern an active part of the body's construction rather than decoration placed on an already completed likeness.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: MP180

08 / 20

Two Nude Women on the Beach

Pablo Picasso

1937 · Musée national Picasso-Paris



Pablo Picasso. Two naked women on the beach. WikiArt source label: Pablo Picasso Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/pablo-picasso/two-naked-women-on-the-beach-1937 · Pablo Picasso Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

The women's attention is directed downwards, but their enlarged limbs dominate the shallow space. A modest shared activity acquires the weight of a monumental grouping. The pressure between rounded forms is more important than a roomy setting: there is little opportunity for the eye to pass around the bodies. Closeness becomes a matter of physical construction.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: MP163

09 / 20

Sleeping Woman with Shutters

Pablo Picasso

1936 · Musée national Picasso-Paris



Pablo Picasso. Sleeper near the shutters. WikiArt source label: Pablo Picasso Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/pablo-picasso/sleeper-near-the-shutters-1936 · Pablo Picasso Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

Head, arm and shoulder fold into a compact sequence of curves. Behind them, the shutters introduce a more regular system of lines. That contrast helps distinguish the sleeper's relaxed position from the room containing her. The figure need not obey ordinary anatomy in every detail for the familiar action of resting a head on an arm to remain clear.

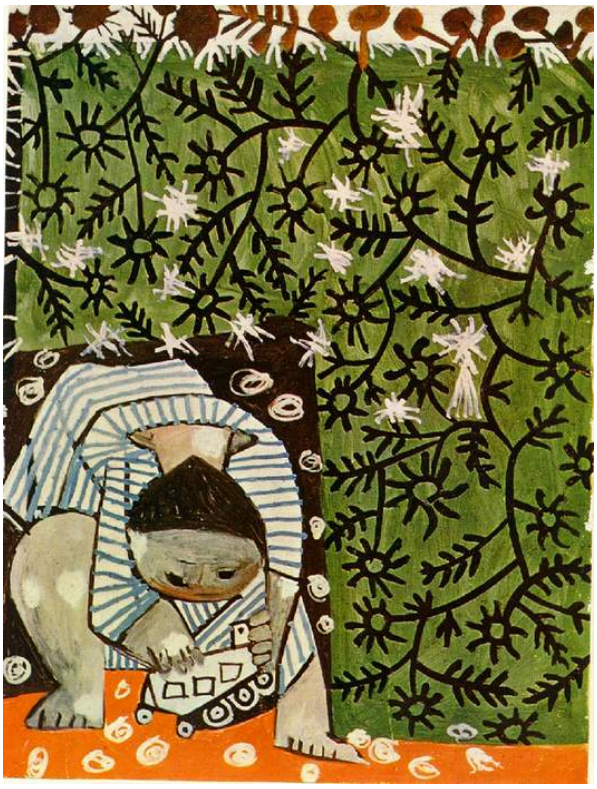
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: MP152

10 / 20

Child Playing with a Truck

Pablo Picasso

1953 · Oil on canvas · Musée national Picasso-Paris



Pablo Picasso. Child playing in camomilles. WikiArt source label: Pablo Picasso Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/pablo-picasso/child-playing-in-camomilles-1953 · Pablo Picasso Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

The toy occupies little space within the busy arrangement of branches and leaves. Yet the child's bent posture gives it a claim on the whole scene: the body directs attention towards the truck. Picasso surrounds that small concentration with restless marks. The contrast preserves a recognisably absorbed activity without making the rest of the painting equally quiet.

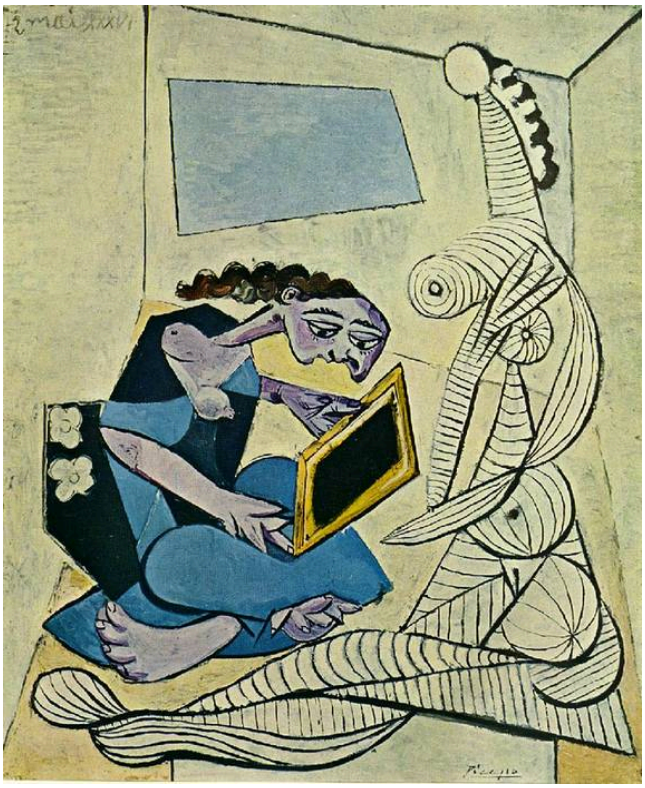
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: MP1990-25

11 / 20

Women in an Interior

Pablo Picasso

1936 · Oil on canvas · Musée national Picasso-Paris



Pablo Picasso. Woman in the interior. WikiArt source label: Pablo Picasso Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/pablo-picasso/woman-in-the-interior-1936 · Pablo Picasso Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

The figures do not fit the room by a single consistent measure. One sits with a book; the larger striped body presses against angled furniture and walls. Instead of correcting that disparity into a plausible interior, Picasso uses it to distinguish ways of occupying space. Domestic familiarity survives even as the room's dimensions become difficult to reconstruct.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: MP156

12 / 20

Figure and Profile

Pablo Picasso

1928 · Oil on canvas · Musée national Picasso-Paris



Pablo Picasso. Figure and profile. WikiArt source label: Pablo Picasso Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/pablo-picasso/figure-and-profile-1928 · Pablo Picasso Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

Several eyes complicate the attempt to read the central outline as one face in one position. The open window nearby is much easier to identify. That ordinary object establishes a standard of legibility against which the figure becomes stranger. The image does not require a final choice between its possible facial readings; their coexistence is part of its structure.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: MP103

13 / 20

Large Bather with a Book

Pablo Picasso

1937 · Musée national Picasso-Paris



Pablo Picasso. Great bather reading. WikiArt source label: Pablo Picasso Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/pablo-picasso/great-bather-reading-1937 · Pablo Picasso Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

The book is small beside the body bent around it. Broad limbs have something of stone's compactness, yet their arrangement communicates the everyday act of reading. Picasso gives concentration a physical enclosure: the massive figure gathers around a modest area of pages. The disproportion makes the activity more conspicuous rather than allowing the body to overwhelm it entirely.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: MP160

14 / 20

Large Still Life on a Pedestal Table

Pablo Picasso

1931 · Oil on canvas · Musée national Picasso-Paris



Pablo Picasso. Great Still life on pedestal. WikiArt source label: Pablo Picasso Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/pablo-picasso/great-still-life-on-pedestal-1931 · Pablo Picasso Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

The objects compete for more space than a tidy tabletop view would allow. Curved outlines run across coloured areas, alternately separating vessels and joining them. Recognition happens locally, a shape at a time, rather than from one dependable viewpoint. The pedestal table provides a subject and an organising constraint, but not a stable little stage for independent objects.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: MP134

15 / 20

The Acrobat

Pablo Picasso

1930 · Oil on canvas · Musée national Picasso-Paris



Pablo Picasso. Female acrobat. WikiArt source label: Pablo Picasso Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/pablo-picasso/female-acrobat-1930 · Pablo Picasso Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

The action takes precedence over anatomical plausibility. Picasso stretches the pale body into a long loop, then uses hands and feet to keep that turn readable as a human pose. The grey ground leaves the bending contour exposed. Tracing it reveals a body organised around continuity of movement rather than the ordinary limits of its joints.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: MP120

16 / 20

Child with Doves

Pablo Picasso

1943 · Oil on canvas · Musée national Picasso-Paris



Pablo Picasso. A child with pigeons. WikiArt source label: Pablo Picasso Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/pablo-picasso/a-child-with-pigeons-1943 · Pablo Picasso Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

Angular furniture fills much of the room around the small child. Pale birds carry attention upwards, while the rounded body remains low within this crowded framework. Differences of scale prevent the grouping from settling into an easy domestic scene. The child's enclosure is visible in the arrangement itself; it does not require an invented account of what the child feels.

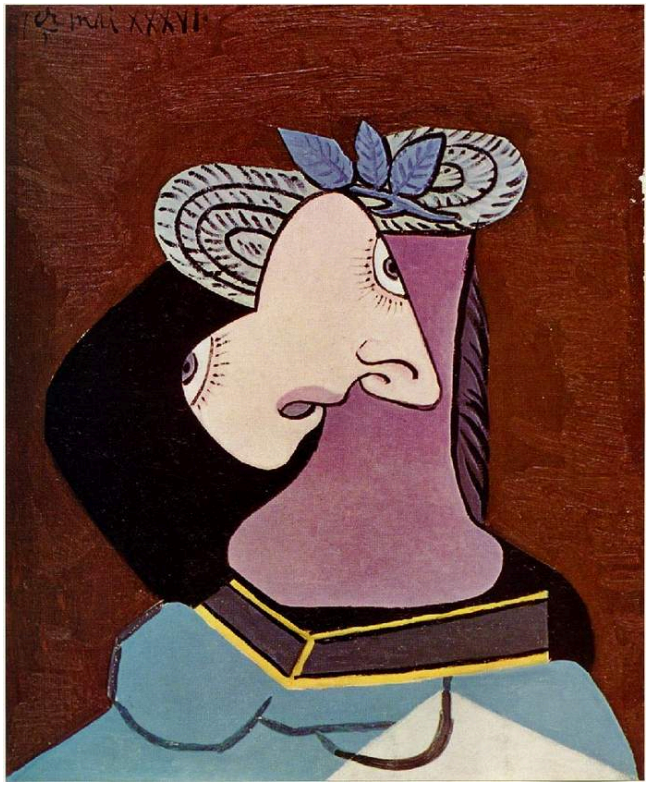
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: MP192

17 / 20

Straw Hat with Blue Foliage

Pablo Picasso

1936 · Oil on canvas · Musée national Picasso-Paris



Pablo Picasso. The straw hat with blue leaves. WikiArt source label: Pablo Picasso Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/pablo-picasso/woman-in-a-straw-hat-1936 · Pablo Picasso Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

The hat has more elaborate incident than the face beneath it. Loops and blue leaves spread above a profile described through a few bounded areas of black, cream and violet. Picasso distributes detail selectively. The portrait remains identifiable without making every part equally informative, and the extravagant headwear gains force from the economy of the facial signs.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: MP155

18 / 20

Paul as Harlequin

Pablo Picasso

1924 · Oil on canvas · Musée national Picasso-Paris



Pablo Picasso. Paul as harlequin. WikiArt source label: Pablo Picasso Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/pablo-picasso/paul-as-harlequin-1924 · Pablo Picasso Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

The diamond costume makes Paul a performer, but his carefully described face and hands keep the portrait attached to a particular child. Less resolved areas around the lower furniture expose a difference in attention across the surface. The theatrical role does not absorb the sitter completely. Costume, likeness and the uneven degree of finish remain separately visible.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: MP83

19 / 20

Massacre in Korea

Pablo Picasso

1951 · Oil on plywood · Musée national Picasso-Paris



Pablo Picasso. Massacre in Korea. WikiArt source label: Pablo Picasso Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/pablo-picasso/massacre-in-korea-1951 · Pablo Picasso Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

A strip of open ground divides exposed women and children from armed figures. That interval is essential: the two groups face one another, but they do not possess comparable means of action. Mechanical-looking weapons intensify the imbalance. The painting's protest emerges from this organisation of force and vulnerability, without needing the figures to resemble a photographic report of a particular moment.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: MP203

20 / 20

Maya with a Doll

Pablo Picasso

1938 · Oil on canvas · Musée national Picasso-Paris



Pablo Picasso. Portrait of Maya with her doll. WikiArt source label: Pablo Picasso Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/pablo-picasso/portrait-of-maya-with-her-doll-1938 · Pablo Picasso Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

Maya's large head and differently directed features complicate the portrait, while the doll makes her activity immediately familiar. Repeated colours connect the toy to the dress and sitter. The altered anatomy does not remove the relation between a child and an object held close. It changes how that companionship occupies the compact picture rather than replacing it with an abstract puzzle.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: MP170

Follow one transformation

Compare the hands in the early portrait, the beach figures and the acrobat. Each must do a different job. This selection is not a promised display route; consult the museum's current information for works available during your visit.

Further reading

Pablo Picasso: A Retrospective

Edited by William Rubin · Digitized catalogue under Publications · English

MoMA provides a digitized copy of William Rubin's 1980 retrospective catalogue under Publications. Its long chronological survey helps place these sharply different works within Picasso's wider production.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12

Artline · Musée national Picasso-Paris: Masterpieces